warlords, how slim the chances were that he would survive. And now, having crossed the Indus a second time, no longer part of a conquering army but a lonely supplicant, Akbar's uncle would learn this, too: that all the operatic fury with which Sulaiman and his cousins had scrambled for a throne was only a pitiful game of musical chairs in the light of Akbar's achievement.

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In July 1540, Mirza Haider, Babur's young cousin and uncle to his four sons – Humayun, Kamran, Askari and Hindal – arrived in Lahore and could hardly find a place to stay. The 'throng was so great', he wrote, 'that it was difficult to move about, and still more difficult to find a lodging'.[5] The crowds were not celebratory, however; no grand coronation was in the offing, no festival or pilgrimage in progress. Instead, a great darkness was descending upon the city. Its streets were panicked, its inns sold out and its gardens packed with tents; all for one reason: a kingdom was crumbling and Lahore was its last refuge.

A little over six weeks earlier, the armies of Humayun, the second Mughal 'padishah',[6] and Sher Shah, the ambitious Afghan general, had faced each other on the banks of the Ganga, in Kannauj. As the north Indian summer crept up on them, there was an occasional skirmish, and more than occasional desertion.[7] Haider, commanding a contingent of Humayun's troops, saw little more than reluctance animate his side. A 'heated feeling ran through the army', he would write later, caustically, 'and the cry was, "Let us go and rest in our own homes."'

Thunderclouds gathered, 'with tumult, like rutting elephants',[8] showing more appetite for battle than the Mughal men. The rain was turning the ground to mush, making it impossible to camp and imperative, therefore, to battle. On 17 May 1540 – which was also Ashura, the tenth of Muharram, the day of Husain's martyrdom upon the bloody battlefield of Karbala – Humayun and his 40,000 men charged a 15,000-strong force led by Sher Shah at Kannauj.

Perhaps 'charged' is not the right word. Haider remembers how there were twenty-seven Mughal contingents between him and the river, each marked by the fluttering banner of its commander. On the day of the battle,